

Skills and Resources Scope and Sequence

This Skills and Resources Scope and Sequence is a practical guide for English Learner instructors.

The Scope and sequence follows the consecutive order of English phonics skills when beginning to read in the English Language. It also lists recommendations and resources available for each English skill taught in the Resource Hub.

Resources and recommendations can be used in whole group, small group, or one-on-one settings.

Teacher resources include:

Virtual trainings, foundational lessons, anchor charts, phonics skill practice routines, and student worksheets.

Student resources include:

Instructional animations in multiple languages to front-load critical English skills.

Family resources include:

Multilingual informational PDFs that foster inclusivity and parental support.

You will notice that most instructional resources consist of instructional animations. Animations are provided in the student's native language (with an English script for the teacher) and intended to front-load the English skill of focus. Each animation falls under three categories. **Articulation Animations, Routine Skill Animations, and Instructional Animations.** **Articulation Animations** show how to articulate English phonemes in real-time. This is beneficial for students learning to articulate and pronounce new and unfamiliar sounds in the English language. **Instructional Animations** explain key phonics skills in the student's native language. **Routine Skill Animations** explain practice routines that can be used to physically apply skills to practice.

Target Language Approach

In each animation video, you will notice that while the majority of the explanation is provided in the student's native language, key terms in English are maintained. This is intentional and in line with target language teaching. The target language is English, and the explanation of those skills for comprehension is in another language.

Maintaining academic and functional vocabulary in the English target language, such as phoneme, grapheme, etc., allows students to more readily relate to and recognize each English term when the English-speaking teacher refers to and uses them in instruction. This approach allows students to independently make necessary connections in the new English skill, as the function of that skill is explained in their native tongue.

Acknowledging and using the student's native language allows them to use what they know to better understand what they are learning. Connections in the new English language can be built when we acknowledge, celebrate, and use the skill sets our students already have!

This targeted approach is strategically designed to recognize and cultivate existing skill sets while developing and targeting new ones.

Each resource referenced in this Scope and Sequence is intentionally designed for the English Learner.

Really Great Reading recognizes and embraces student culture and language. Both are an asset necessary for successful English literacy and language proficiency.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTION

What if I do not understand or speak the other language?

There is no prerequisite for an instructor to speak or understand another language to teach English skills to an English learner effectively. Remember, the target language is English. What better person could teach it than someone fluent and trained to teach English reading? Be encouraged!

Our instructional videos, in multiple languages, are designed to support English instruction. The explanation for the skill of focus in another language will boost students' engagement and encourage independent connections as the teacher is teaching and practicing the explained skill in English.

With this approach, teachers and students can be equipped and empowered during English instruction!

Instructional Animations Application

Each instructional animation is encouraged to be played before English instruction of that skill takes place. This initial explanation, in another language, will front load the skill of focus, providing for a more meaningful experience.

Having the skill of focus explained in the student's native language provides instant connection, increased comprehension, and more active participation during English instruction.

Your language learner students will be better prepared to understand and apply their new English skills in real time. Animations can be used for small-group, individual, and even whole-group instruction.

Culturally Responsive Animations

Apart from instructional animations, you will notice some specific animations labeled as culturally responsive. These animations are designed with the English learner in mind when considering how to make unfamiliar content more relatable.

There are some specific animations meant to connect and reference new and unfamiliar English skills taught. Each are listed below.



[Resources in English>Language Selection>Instructional Animations>Culturally Responsive Animations](#)

[Resources in Other Languages>Language Selection>Instructional Animations>Culturally Responsive Animations](#)

English Learner Classroom Strategies

When students are newcomers or at a beginning level in their English proficiency, they are tasked with making sense of their classroom environment in day-to-day functions, learning to speak the new English language orally, and learning to read in that language. This can be daunting. The "English Learner Strategies" animation equip students with the knowledge to use the tools they already have to make sense of the new language as they are developing in it.



[Resources in English>Language Selection>Instructional Animations>Culturally Responsive animations](#)

[Resources in Other Languages>Language Selection>Instructional Animations>Culturally Responsive animations](#)



FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTION

How will I understand what resources in other languages are saying?

Apart from being highly visual, each instructional animation has an English script option that teachers can reference. This will let the teacher know what is said and how the skill is explained. This scope and sequence also references each animation and resource applicable to the skill of focus, alongside instructional recommendations and considerations for the teacher.

Note:

Each animation explains phonics skills practically and is designed to be purposeful when making content culturally and linguistically relatable.

Parent Resources are bilingual, meaning they are provided in English and another language. Teachers can send both the English and other language versions home or simply keep and reference the English PDF for themselves.

Resources are currently provided in the following languages:

Arabic	Haitian Creole
Korean	Mandarin
Somali	Spanish
Vietnamese	Tagalog

Nonsense Words

You will notice a “Nonsense Word” animation. Evidence Based research indicates that English learners strive to give meaning to new words in the language they are learning. Because of this, practicing to read with nonsense words can be an abstract and confusing concept. Nonsense words however, are an integral part of practicing combining letters to sound in the English language. Our Nonsense Word animation explains the reasoning behind nonsense words and uses a visual reference that can be applied when nonsense words are practiced. If students are given the opportunity to understand the reasoning behind the use of nonsense words they can equally practice reading with them amongst their peers. Teachers are recommended to use this visual support (found in our English picture vocabulary cards) when using nonsense word for reading practice. This will remind students of the purpose of nonsense words and reassure them that they are simply practicing combining letters and sounds with no meaning to be sought after in the new Language. We recommend using this visual each and every time nonsense words are referenced or practiced in order to build students' confidence as they gain more ease and fluency in their ability to decode.



[Resources in English>Language Selection>Instructional Animations>Culturally Responsive animations](#)
[Resources in Other Languages>Language Selection>Instructional Animations>Culturally Responsive animations](#)

Heart Words

Really Great Reading uses the concept of Heart Words when referring to sight words. While some sight words can be remembered and are phonetic, others have “tricky parts” that don’t necessarily “sound as they should.” These parts have to be remembered “by heart.” The expression of knowing “something by heart” is very much an English one and doesn’t necessarily translate contextually in other languages. The Heart Word animation contextually explains the purpose of Heart Words using the concept of family. Families across many cultures are held in high regard. There are members of our family we hold dear and remember by keeping them in our hearts. This concept is tied to explaining the definition and use of Heart Words, making the English expression “by heart” relatable.



[Resources in English>Language Selection>Instructional Animations>Culturally Responsive animations](#)
[Resources in Other Languages>Language Selection>Instructional Animations>Culturally Responsive animations](#)



Skill Routine Practice Animations

Evidence-based practice shows us that one of the biggest disconnects for English learners is applying skills to practice. Most English instruction typically only focuses on academic skills but takes the instruction needed for skill application for granted. English learners are learning a new language orally and academically. This means that apart from the academic skill itself, they must be supported and guided in understanding how to practice it.

The assumption that skill practice activities are naturally understood does not apply to non-native speakers because they are challenged to make sense of the skill while also processing and understanding how to use it in the new language.

The Resource Hub provides multisensory practice skills for teachers to continuously use as they reinforce new skills taught. "Routine Skill" animations explain these practice skills in the student's native language before the teacher engages in the skills practice activity. This gives the student the confidence and knowledge to understand and participate in applying skills to practice.



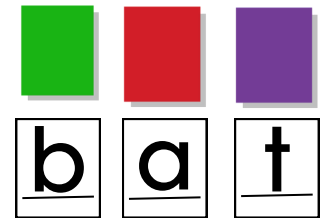
[Resources in Other Languages](#)>[Language Selection](#)>[Instructional Animations](#)>[Skill Practice Animations](#)



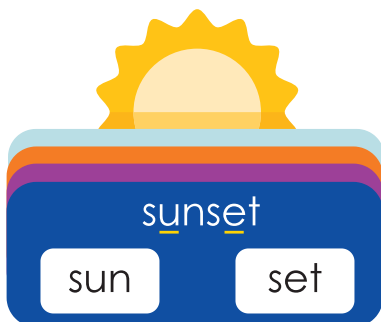
Finger Stretching



Touch and Say



Build a Word



Lose the Rules



Spell It!



Multisensory Routine Skills

Evidence Based Research also shows that multisensory approaches provide for optimal learning. Brain science shows us that applying all the senses when learning provides multiple opportunities for neural connections to be formed. When connections are formed, comprehension follows. This is especially beneficial for English learners who are not only learning new skills, but also learning how to comprehend and apply those skills in a new language. One researched practice that considers this multisensory approach in language teaching is known as Total Physical Response. We encourage this approach through our practice activities that teachers and students can use to routinely apply the skills to practice. Applying new skills in a tangible way allows students to better understand the skill's function. Explanations of these skill activities are provided via animation in multiple languages. Before engaging in the routine practice activity, the teacher can play the animation that explains the practice activity. This will allow the student to understand the purpose of the routine and actively engage, as well as make independent connections as they practice the new English skill with their teacher.

For optimal instruction use our Phonics Kit alongside these practice activities as students begin the English reading journey. Play the Phonics Kit Animation found in Skill Practice Animations in the Resource Hub. This animation will explain the manipulatives and their purpose before using them alongside Skill Practice Activities.

Skill Practice Descriptions

Practice Activity



[Resources in Other Languages](#)> [Language Selection](#)>[Instructional Animations](#)
>[Skill Practice Animations](#)

Finger-Stretching

A multisensory routine that enables letter-to-sound correspondence for the accurate decoding of words.

The teacher says the word, and the student repeats the word as they make a fist. Then, they stretch out a letter for every sound they hear in the word, and then close their hand back into a fist while saying the entire word again.

Touch and Say

A multisensory routine that enables letter to sound correspondence

The teacher models and enables the student to independently “touch and say” each letter and their sound as they blend words.



Multisensory Routine Skills

Build a Word

A multisensory routine that enables letter-to-sound correspondence for both decoding and encoding skills

This routine is used with manipulatives and can be used with our online letter tile freeplay or our phonics kits. Color tiles represent sounds heard (red tiles represent vowel sounds) and are chosen and placed down as each sound is identified in a word. Letter tiles can then be placed beneath each sound (represented by a color tile) as the word is built and read.

Lose the Rules

A multisensory routine activity that enables blending and segmenting of syllables through the use of sylla-boards.

It is ideal to use the sylla-boards found in the phonics kits for this activity; however, notecards or pieces of paper can also be used. First, the teacher presents the student with a word and asks the student to identify how many vowels are seen in a word. Next, the student chooses one sylla-board or piece of paper, per vowel identified. The student then writes each vowel on each sylla-board or piece of paper before filling in the remaining empty spaces with the remaining consonant letters in the word. Students can identify each syllable or part of the complex word before blending them to read entirely!

Spell It!

A multisensory routine that reinforces the alphabetic principle and strengthens phonemic awareness and decoding skills for both reading and spelling.

This routine can be applied using the printable spell it template found in printable resources. The student will fill in a circle for each sound heard, and then will proceed to fill in the letter or letters that represent those sounds in each box (below the filled in circle).

Skill

Newcomer Strategies for making meaning in the new English classroom environment.

Resource Available

Primary and Intermediate EL Comprehension Strategies Animation

[Resources in Other Languages](#)> [Language of Choice](#)>[Culturally Responsive Animations](#)

Primary and Intermediate EL Strategies Anchor Chart

[Resources in English](#)>[Printable Resources](#)

Language Consideration

English learners, particularly newcomers and students with beginning proficiency, are tasked with not only functioning in a new language but also speaking and learning it. This can prove quite overwhelming.

Highlighting students' reasoning abilities and how to use those to infer better meaning in the new language is crucial for their daily functionality, independence, self-esteem, and self-confidence.

When your student is aware and equipped with the tools necessary to function and make sense of things in their new language surroundings, they can better focus and actively participate during instruction.

Teacher Recommendations

It is recommended that this animation be played in the student's native language and used in conjunction with its anchor chart for immediate referencing. Once your students have watched this animation, they will better understand strategies they can use to function in the classroom as they learn the new English language. If your student looks "lost" during daily transitions or instruction, point to the anchor chart to remind them of the strategies they can use. The anchor chart references the animation that explains functional strategies that can be applied. This is meant to reassure and remind students of ways they can independently "carry on" even when they don't yet understand everything that is being said.

Skill

Phonemes

Resource Available

What is a Phoneme? Animation

[Resources in Other Languages](#)> [Language of Choice](#)>[Instructional Animations](#)

Finger Stretching Animation

[Resources in Other Languages](#)> [Language of Choice](#)>[Instructional Animations](#)

Language Consideration

Depending on your student's language and whether they have a background in academics, in their native language, many students can easily comprehend letter to sound or symbol to sound in literacy. For some, however, this might be a more unfamiliar concept, especially if they speak and read in a language where symbols are tied to entire words. Understanding letters to make sound identification is crucial for English learners. Remember that in addition to unfamiliar letters, their sounds might be equally so. Tying sounds to letters is additionally beneficial, as this visual presentation (the grapheme/letter) reiterates and gives meaning to new sounds being heard and learned in the new language.

Teacher Recommendations

Before learning every sound that belongs to every letter, play the "What is a Phoneme" animation to ensure your student understands that every letter represents a sound in the English alphabet.

Once your student has established their short vowel sounds and some consonant letters, they can begin to build and read simple words while also continuing to learn the remaining letters and their sounds.

Before teaching and practicing building new words with letters and their sounds, play the "Letters Make Sounds" animation to ensure your student understands that every letter makes a sound and that combining those sounds creates words.

Before practicing using your phonics kit, play the "Phonics Kit" animation that explains the functionality of the pieces of the kit in your student's native language. This explanation will boost engagement, comprehension, and eventual independent practice as your student is guided to build and read new words using their kits.

Identifying this skill and practicing it with the tangible phonics kits will help reiterate and make reading concepts more concrete for your English Learner student. It is helpful for your English learner to have a physical and visual representation (color tiles and letter tiles) of the new skill and practice of identifying sounds and their letters and then combining those to read in English. Remember that it is not uncommon for your students to be learning what new words mean at the same time they are learning to decode them. Use our English Picture Vocabulary Cards to apply meaning to words being built. Make sure to use the nonsense word visual when nonsense words are being used for practice.

Letter to Sound Correspondence

Resource Available

Letters and Their Sounds Make Words Animation

[Resources in Other Languages](#)> [Language of Choice](#)>[Instructional Animations](#)

Build a Word Routine Animation

[Resources in Other Languages](#)> [Language of Choice](#)>[Instructional Animations](#)

Phonics Kit Animation

[Resources in Other Languages](#)> [Language of Choice](#)>[Instructional Animations](#)

Letter Sound Linking Chart

[Resources in English](#)> [Printable Resources](#)>[Anchor Charts](#)

[Physical/Digital Phonics Kit](#)

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Skill

Short Vowels

Resource Available

Short Vowel Articulation

[Resources in English](#)> [Instructional Animations](#)>[Vowel Articulations](#)

Short Vowels Animation

[Resources in English](#)> [Instructional Animations](#)>[Vowel and Consonants](#)

Short Vowels Anchor Chart

[Resources in English](#)>
[Printable Resources](#)>[Anchor Charts](#)

Language Consideration

Vowels in various languages may have only one sound or multiple tonal variations. In English, the distinct short and long vowel sounds are crucial and need to be taught clearly. When approaching English vowel sounds, it is recommended that they be highlighted as unique in that they have two sounds instead of only one.

Teacher Recommendations

Your English Learner has just begun to understand that every letter has a sound in addition to new letters, words, and sounds. While it is recommended to mention and highlight that English vowels have long and short sounds, it is also recommended that apart from this awareness, you first establish short vowel sounds before requiring long vowel skills. Most English words contain short vowel sounds. This skill is crucial for establishing the foundation for reading simple words before considering long vowel sounds found in more complex words. You may also play the articulation videos as you focus on each vowel within the pacing of your curriculum. Use our "Short Vowel Movements" animations to reinforce their sounds and or review them. The Short Vowels Anchor chart and its movements for each short vowel sound is an excellent reference and can prove highly beneficial. Practice each movement assigned to each vowel sound alongside vowel identification and articulation with your students. Doing this will make this skill more applicable and concrete for your English Learner.

Skill

Long Vowels

Resource Available

Long Vowel Articulation

[Resources in English](#)> [Instructional Animations](#)>[Vowel Articulations](#)

Long Vowels Animation

[Resources in English](#)> [Instructional Animations](#)>[Vowel and Consonants](#)

Long Vowels Anchor Chart

[Resources in English](#)>
[Printable Resources](#)>[Anchor Charts](#)

Language Consideration

Vowels in various languages may have only one sound or multiple tonal variations. In English, the distinct short and long vowel sounds are crucial and need to be taught clearly. When approaching English vowel sounds, it is recommended that they be highlighted as unique in that they have two sounds instead of only one. Students should be able to identify short vowel sounds first, with an understanding that another sound exists for vowels when applicable.

Teacher Recommendations

Once your student is comfortable decoding cvc (consonant-vowel-consonant) words containing short vowels, they will be ready to apply the long vowel sounds and when they are applied when they begin to encounter more complex words in the English language. Your English Learner is tasked with twice the cognitive overload in acquiring new sounds, new concepts and new skills in the new language. Establishing and focusing on short vowel sounds first instills confidence in the majority of beginning words being read and allows for one skill (short vowel sounds) to be well established before the other. Evidence based research has shown that English learner students already have the challenge of differentiating the new short vowel sounds from one another without the need for wondering if they are long or short at the very beginning. When the identification and articulation of short vowel sounds are well established, it is then an indicator that the English Learner student is ready for long vowel sound review and application. Students cannot and will not encounter long vowel sounds in more complex words before short vowel sounds in the majority of simpler words are able to be read. Having the short vowel sound skill establish with awareness of another that exists and is yet to come increases confidence and focus on one ability at a time in the new language, providing for a more seamless transition and simultaneous use of short and long vowel sounds. Use our short vowels movement animations to reinforce their sounds and or review them. The Short Vowels Anchor chart and its movements in the animations, for each short vowel sound, is an excellent reference and can prove highly beneficial.

Skill

Difference between long and Short Vowels

Resource Available

Long Vowels Animation

[Resources in Other Languages](#)> [Instructional Animations](#)>[Vowels and Consonants](#)

Long and Short Vowels Anchor Charts

[Resources in English](#)> [Instructional Animations](#)>[Vowels and Consonants](#)

Language Consideration

Differentiation of both long and short vowel sounds in the English language is crucial as your student begins to develop and read more complex words in the English language.

Teacher Recommendations

Awareness that English vowels have two sounds and the establishment of short vowel sounds first followed by an in depth look at long vowels and their application, has proven to be a successful path when instructing English Learners in vowel skills in English.

Reiterating and differentiating the two is also crucial for accurate reading and spelling in literacy development. Play The Difference Between Long and Short Vowels to reiterate or review differentiation once the student has established their understanding and use of short vowels in reading beginning words. As your student begins to approach more complex words, long vowels will appear, and recognizing them is crucial for accurate decoding.

It is recommended that when practicing articulating short vowel sounds, your sounds are short and concise so as to be explicitly different when heard and articulated by EL students who will be prolonging the long vowel sounds as they say the name of each letter. Unfamiliar sounds can often all sound the same, as vowels are the essence of English word hearing, and articulating the differences between long and short vowels is crucial for accurate reading to occur.

Skill

Decoding Single Syllable Words

Resource Available

Letters and Their Sounds Make Words Animation

[Resources in Other Languages](#)> [Language of Choice](#)>[Instructional Animations](#)>[Vowels and Consonants](#)

Phonics Kit Animation

[Resources in Other Languages](#)> [Language of Choice](#)>[Instructional Animations](#)>[Skill Practice Animations](#)

Build a Word Routine Animation

[Resources in Other Languages](#)> [Language of Choice](#)>[Instructional Animations](#)> [Skill Practice Activities](#)

English Picture Vocabulary Cards

[Resources in English](#)> [Printable Resources](#)

Language Consideration

While some languages also have letter to symbol correspondence and similar mechanics in reading, other languages do not. Regardless, letter to sound correspondence of simple cvc words in English is a necessary foundational skill that students must independently master to begin to read accurately in the English language.

Teacher Recommendations

Being able to conceptualize and the blending of letters and sounds in a concrete manner is key for ensuring English Learner success as they begin to read. Rather it is the mechanics of reading and English words or the English word itself, these concepts are foreign and must be taught in a way that is tangible and applicable through practice. Play the “Letters and Their Sounds Make Words” animation and use the build a word routine to practice via our the phonics kit to ensure your student knows how to accurately begin to decode new English words. Keep in mind that your student is not only learning the mechanics of how to identify letters and their sounds as well as combine them, but is also learning what those new beginning vocabulary words mean. Use our picture vocabulary cards to reinforce new English words being built and practiced.

Skill

Nonsense Words

Resource Available

What is a Nonsense Word

[Resources in English](#)> [Culturally Responsive Animations](#)

What is a Nonsense Word

[Resources in Other Languages](#)> [Culturally Responsive Animations](#)

English Picture Vocabulary Cards - Nonsense Words

[Resources in English](#)>

[Printable Resources](#)>[Instructional Resources](#)

Language Consideration

Once your student has begun decoding simple cvc words they will typically encounter nonsense words in the English language. For an English Learner, Nonsense Words can prove a bit confusing, as your EL student is naturally tying meaning to each new concept being learned in the new language. Being informed on what Nonsense Words are and that they are simply for practice, will build your student's confidence and reassure them as they come across these when practicing to read in English. EL Students have the ability to understand the difference, they just simply need an explanation. This explanation is necessary not only because ELs are seeking meaning in all aspects in the new language, but also because the use of "nonsense words" in reading practice is not common in other languages and very specific to the English one, due to its irregular patterns. Understanding the difference between real and Nonsense Words will further equip your EL student as they encounter different word types and the word's purpose, when beginning to read in the English language.

Teacher Recommendations

Nonsense words are used in the English language due to the language structure's irregular patterns. Beginning readers will often encounter what is known as Nonsense Words in the English language simply to practice blending specific letters and sounds of focus to better facilitate decoding skills. This animation is a culturally responsive animation and is also provided in the English language for the teacher to fully grasp the context of how this English reading skill is made applicable to different languages and cultures. We recommend you as the teacher to first watch the Nonsense Word explanation and then to play the animation in your student's native language before beginning to practice building and reading Nonsense Words in English. In the "What is a Nonsense Word" animation, a visual prompt is used anytime a nonsense word is to be practiced. This prompt is available and found in your English picture vocabulary cards found in the English printable resources. Use this visual each time you have students practice reading with nonsense words. This will reassure the student of the word's purpose, letting them know that this is simply practicing combining letters and their sounds, lessening the pressure and cognitive load of trying to also understand the English word's meaning.

Skill

Heart Words

Resource Available

What is a Heart Word

[Resources in English](#)> [Culturally Responsive Animations](#)

What is a Heart Word

[Resources in Other Languages](#)> [Culturally Responsive Animations](#)

English Picture Vocabulary Cards - Heart Words

[Resources in English](#)>

[Printable Resources](#)>[Instructional Resources](#)

Language Consideration

Due to the English language and its highly irregular phoneme and spelling structure, students are often taught to read what are considered irregular English words through the concept of sight words or heart words. Heart Words go beyond just memorization and teaches students that these words have “tricky parts” that one must remember by heart. This teaches the student to approach new words with confidence by using their phoneme knowledge for regular spelling patterns, while recognizing irregular ones in a word and knowing how to read them. Heart Words (Sight Words) are very specific English language reading practice and is not typically used in other language structures when teaching reading. This can prove confusing to EL students if they have just learned that every letter has a sound, what those are and know that those letters “don’t always sound as they should” when coming across irregularly spelled words. Taking the time to explain the concept of Heart Words and preparing your student in knowing what to expect as they encounter these irregularities (through the use of Heart Words) will equip them with the tools necessary to decode irregular English words correctly. Where heart words (sight words) may include regularly spelled words such as “and” your student will be able to approach these with ease by simply sounding out the word should it be needed.

Teacher Recommendations

Once your student has begun to read beginning words, they will most likely encounter Heart Words or Sight Words in their decoding books and curriculum during instruction. Using Heart Words(Sight Words) to increase fluency is a practice common to the English language. It is because of this that the concept requires an explanation and background knowledge to be established before its use with EL students during reading. The idiom “learning something by heart” is also rooted in English and American culture. This concept requires a somewhat different explanation because it must be explained in a way that is relatable to other cultures. The concept of family is held in high regard across multiple cultures, and we purposefully use this concept when explaining the need to keep special parts of words inside one’s heart (memory). We recommend playing the “What is a Heart Word” animation in your student’s native language, so that the concept is relatable and purposeful for your student as they begin to use Heart Words (Sight Words) in English reading instruction and practice. This animation is a culturally responsive animation and is also provided in the English language, for the teacher to fully grasp the message and context of its explanation. We recommend that the teacher watches it as well before showing it to the student. To reference Heart Words, there are also two visual cards found in the English picture vocabulary cards that teachers can use as a prompt during Heart Word use in instruction and practice.

Skill

Digraphs

Resource Available

What is a Digraph

[Resources in Other Languages](#)> [Language of Choice](#)>[Instructional Animations](#)

Digraph Anchor Chart

[Physical Resources Anchor Chart Set](#)

English Picture Vocabulary Cards - Simple Digraph Words

[Resources in English](#)> [Printable Resources](#)

Language Consideration

Digraphs have the same if not similar functions in some languages, but not in all. Regardless, digraphs and their use in the English language, will be a new concept for your EL student and must be clearly explained. As your student begins to read, they will start with simple cvc words before tackling simple words with digraphs. Your EL student is very much dependent on sound to symbol, as they rely on the visual cue of the English letter to then tie it to the English sound they have learned. Teaching students that sometimes in English, two letters have one sound is something that must be done progressively and explicitly for clear ability in decoding words with digraphs to ensue.

Teacher Recommendations

We recommend not teaching words with digraphs until the ability to decode simple cvc (consonant vowel consonant) words has been established. Your EL student must learn and be confident that every letter has a sound before being thrown the “curveball” that some letter sets when combined form one sound. Once they are comfortable reading simple cvc words and have mastered their letters and their sounds they will be able to confidently apply new knowledge to the six digraph sets in the English language known as sh, th, ch, ck, wh, ph. We recommend starting with the digraph sh as its sound is a universal one used to keep one quiet and can be relatable to the student when articulating it. We also recommend teaching the concept of a digraph with applying one-the sh while referencing the other specific pairs. Once the function of one digraph has been established, we recommend progressively teaching and practicing with other digraph pairs. Teaching each digraph individually and scaffolding is important to ensure that this concept is concrete and well established for your EL student. Once they have grasped this concept, they will be able to readily recognize and confidently read words that contain these digraphs when seen in new words. Before teaching and practicing digraphs, we recommend playing the explanation of “What is a Digraph” in your student’s native language. This animation explains the concept using the sh while referencing the others. The explanation of a digraph in your student’s native language will ensure they fully understand its concept so that they are ready to apply it when you practice reading with digraphs in English. We also have simple words with digraphs found in our English picture vocabulary cards and recommend using these with your students to build and read new simple words with digraphs. These words and their pictures will help your student build their English vocabulary, as they are also applying the skill of the words structure in the English language.

Skill

Closed Syllables

Resource Available

What is a Closed Syllable

[Resources in Other Languages](#)>[Language of Choice](#)> [Instructional Animations](#)> [Syllables and Syllable Types](#)

Closed Syllable Practice Activity

[Resources in English](#)>[Printable Resources](#)>[Open Closed Syllable Worksheet Activity](#)

Hand Gestures Anchor Chart

[Resources in English](#)>
[Anchor Charts](#)

Lose the Rules Skill Practice Activity

[Resources in Other Languages](#)>[Language of Choice](#)>
[Instructional Animations](#)>[Skills Practice Animation](#)

Language Consideration

Closed Syllables are highly important when teaching the English language, as they are the foundation of what enables students to later “break up” larger English words and accurately decode them. Understanding the term for closed syllable and what a closed syllable is are equally important for your English Learner. Once your student is able to identify and read closed syllables, they will have the ability to read 53% of all words in the English language. As your student begins to read cvc and simple digraph words with fluency, they will be encountering more complex and longer words in English. Many of these words contain closed syllables. Many languages contain syllable and syllable types, however their function is distinct to each language. Teaching syllable types in English should be taught explicitly to your English Learner to ensure they can practice and apply the skills of English syllables to English words.

Teacher Recommendations

Play “What is a Closed Syllable” animation before using the term and its practice in reading. This will ensure that the concept has been explained in your student’s native language so that they can readily recognize both term and purpose of closed syllables as you practice in your instruction. Use the hand gesture referenced in our anchor chart every time you refer to closed syllables to reiterate and solidify this English concept for your English Learner. We also recommend using our closed syllable worksheet, which can be used in your small group and additionally sent home to practice and familiarize students with identifying and reading closed syllables in English. Establishing this skill will prepare your students for the Really Great Readings’s Lose the Rules practice routine, which enables students to “chunk” or break off longer complex words in English with ease and fluency. Once your student can easily read cvc and simple digraph words, they are ready to approach larger words with closed syllables and to apply the use of syllable-boards. Play the “Lose the Rules” animation found in Practice Skill Routines in your student’s native language once this concept has been established, and you are ready to practice more complex words with closed syllables.

Skill

Open Syllables

Resource Available

What is an Open Syllable

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Language Consideration

English has six syllable types and the most common seen in words are closed syllables along with open and vowel team syllables. Once your student has understood the purpose and term for closed syllables in English, they are ready to learn about open syllables. Having an established understanding of vowels and consonants in the English language will solidify the concept of different syllable types and their application in English. This concept should be explicitly taught once your EL student has an understanding and foundation in vowels and consonants, reading simple cvc and digraph words and closed syllables. This is important because rather your student has formal education in their native language or non, this concept will be new in the English one.

Teacher Recommendations

It is recommended that that your student first master reading and recognizing words with closed syllables, before instruction of open syllables. This will ensure a smooth transition in the natural evolution of your student's English literacy skill development. Once students have mastered closed syllables and are comfortable with identifying those patterns, via the "Lose the Rules" routine, they will be ready to confidently approach reading newer words at the next level. These words contain both closed and/or open syllable types. Play "What is an Open Syllable" animation before using the term and its practice in reading. This will ensure that the concept has been explained in your student's native language so that they can readily recognize both term and purpose of open syllables during instruction. Use the hand gesture referenced in our anchor chart every time you refer to open syllables to reiterate and solidify this English concept for your English Learner. We also recommend using our open syllable worksheet, which can be used in your small group and additionally sent home to practice and familiarize students with identifying and reading open syllables in English. Establishing this skill, will prepare your students to continue to progress in their reading abilities as they begin to encounter more complex words (with multiple syllable types). Students already familiar with looking for the patterns of closed syllables through the "Lose the Rules" routine will be equipped and ready to apply that same skill set to yet another syllable type (open syllables) found in words.